"HAVE ORDERS BUT UNABLE TO SHIP DUE TO GULF CLOSURE"

Sminu Jindal, Managing Director, Jindal SAW Ltd, on the impact of the West Asia war, policy support, and more

BY **RICHA SHARMA**

SMINU JINDAL, A commerce graduate from Shri Ram College of Commerce, joined Jidal Saw, part of the OP Jindal Group, as a management trainee at the age of 19 in 1992. She did not let her reduced movement ability due to a childhood accident impact her business prowess. In 2001, she took over as the Managing Director of Jindal Saw and has been successfully steering the business by diversifying in the oil and gas sector.

The US-Iran conflict is adversely impacting the steel business. Jindal, however, remians optimistic. She says the war provides new opportunities as the world is now thinking beyond shipping routes and looking to invest in pipelines for movement of oil and gas. She also talks about similar possibilities in India.

In an interview with *Business Today*, Jindal talks about the National Steel Policy and its impact on the high-grade imported steel required for the piped business. She also spoke about her work with people with reduced mobility and association with the Ministry of Sports ahead of the Commonwealth Games 2030 in Ahmedabad. Edited excerpts:

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How has the West Asia war impacted business?

The US-Iran war has disrupted the whole economy, especially in terms of transportation. It's becoming very tough to reach our places of contract because of uncertainty around the Strait of Hormuz. But we are hopeful that next year should be brighter, and we are hedging ourselves better.

We've got our Indian operation in terms of water pipelines, as well as we do a lot of other projects with different oil majors. So, it's keeping a little bit of our neck above water, but it's not a happy situation.

Our order books for the pipe business alone are over a million tonnes as of now. Approximately 20% of our volume that goes to West Asia is currently impacted right now. We have orders but we are not able to ship. The only issue is logistics because both the Gulf and the Red Sea are also closed. Otherwise, 80% of the other business is going as per plan.

Even though it looks very bleak, I don't see myself doing very badly. Some businesses will definitely be impacted. I wouldn't say that we are going to match the numbers we did last year.

> IN THE SHORT TERM, THERE IS STRESS FOR ALL OF US, BUT IN THE LONG TERM WE SEE HUGE BENEFITS"

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Has there been any delaying of orders and reworking of strategy due to the current geo-political situation?

Jindal SAW was looking at divestment in West Asia. So, you can make out that there is going to be a little bit of stalling,